

World imperialism

The Industrial Revolution began in Britain in the mid-1700s, and it transformed world politics and economics. Within a century, European nations were strong and rich enough to set up colonies all around the world. Only the United States of America was able to resist European influence.



Global economy

During the 19th century, European steamships took raw materials from their colonies to factories in Europe, and shipped out finished goods to markets abroad. The huge industrial cities of Europe gained vast wealth, but at the expense of poor producers in African and Asian colonies.

Nationalism

During the 19th century, many of the peoples of Europe struggled to obtain their freedom from outside rulers. In one year, 1848, Italians, Germans, Hungarians, Poles, Irish, and others fought for independence or fairer forms of government.

Fighting at
Catania, Italy,
1848



Soldiers' hats,
1914

World wars

Twice in the 20th century, European conflicts led to war on every continent. In 1914, national rivalries resulted in a four-year war that cost 22 million lives. Germany was defeated and dissatisfied with the peace treaty. Again, war broke out in 1939. By the end of that war, in 1945, Europe was exhausted. Two superpowers, the USA and the Soviet Union, now dominated international affairs.

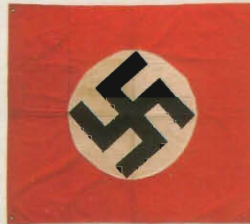
End of empires

World War I led to the defeat of four great European empires – Germany, Austro-Hungary, Russia, and Turkey – and weakened both Britain and France. After World War II, Europe's overseas colonies fought successfully for independence, with only France retaining sizeable overseas possessions.

The double-headed eagle
symbol of Germany



Flag of
Nazi
Germany



Rival ideologies

Communism was established in Russia after 1917 and in Eastern Europe after 1945, while Fascism and Nazism took hold in Italy, Germany, and Spain in the years up to 1945. By 1990, parliamentary democracy, at first weak in Europe, was the dominant form of government.

Iron Curtain

After World War II, Russian troops occupied much of Eastern Europe. A clear border, known as the Iron Curtain, emerged between the Russian-dominated east and American-dominated west. The border split Germany into two countries.



Checkpoint between two sectors of the city of Berlin

Modern Europe

After World War II, French and German politicians worked together to overcome their old hostilities. Economic collaboration between the two countries developed into a formal European Union that grew to include many other western European countries. With the collapse of communism and the rise of market economies in Eastern Europe, many former communist countries lined up to join the EU.

Collapse of Communism

During the late 1980s, Russia withdrew its military and economic support from its communist allies in Eastern Europe. Popular protests then overthrew communism in every East European nation by 1990, but by the late 1990s, there was deep unrest in many East European countries.



Revolution on the streets of Romania

Willy Brandt

Willy Brandt (1913–92) was born in Lübeck, Germany, but lived in Norway during World War II, where he was active in the Resistance. As Chancellor of West Germany from 1969–74, Brandt worked to improve east-west relations and made treaties with Poland and the USSR. He was awarded the 1971 Nobel Peace Prize.



Timeline

c.1250 BC Mycenaean culture flourishes in Greece.

c.900 BC Greek city-states gain power.

c.753 BC Rome is founded.

c.200 BC Celts spread across Europe.



Bronze statue
of Roman
legionary

AD 117 Roman Empire is at its height.

1054 Christian Church splits into Orthodox east and Roman Catholic west.

1500s European nations use their navigation skills to explore and colonize large parts of the globe.

Mid-1700s Industrial Revolution begins to transform the European economy.

1871 The map of Europe is transformed as Germany and Italy become unified nations.

1914–18 World War I.

1939–45 World War II.



Flag of European
Union

1940s–80s Europe gives up most of its colonies.

1957 EEC is set up.

1989–91 Communism falls.

1994 Outbreak of war in Southeast Europe.

2001 Euro is launched.

FIND OUT
MORE

CELTS

COLD
WAR

EMPIRES

GOVERNMENTS
AND POLITICS

GREECE,
ANCIENT

HOLY ROMAN
EMPIRE

MEDIEVAL
EUROPE

ROMAN
EMPIRE

WORLD
WAR I

WORLD
WAR II